

Copilot Triage Decision Tree

Fast symptom-to-investigation path for the Copilot help desk

US Government Publishing Office | Microsoft Copilot | GCC tenant

Version 1.0 | September 29, 2026

Owner: Copilot Operations Team (Tier 2) | Review: quarterly, next January 2027

Companion artifacts: Tier 1 Quick Reference, Escalation Matrix, GCC Feature Reference, Ticket Intake Template, Known Issues Playbook, Admin Portal Map, Monitoring Checklist

Built on the six-layer troubleshooting model from the Copilot Operations course (Day 7).

Click paths verified against Microsoft Learn as of September 2026. Examples are fictional.

Principle: classification before remediation. Collect evidence before changing anything.

How to use this decision tree

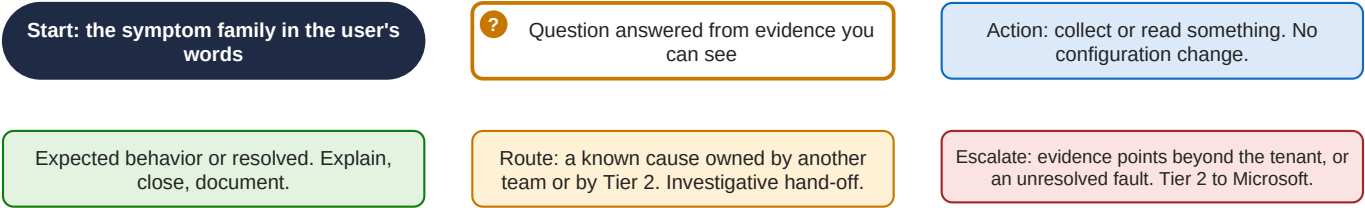
This document is the fast path from a user's words to the right investigation. It does not replace judgment; it makes sure the first ten minutes of every Copilot ticket are spent on the same evidence in the same order, so that Tier 1 resolves what Tier 1 can resolve and escalates with a complete package when it cannot.

The two rules that make it work

- **Classification before remediation.** Decide which of the six layers the symptom most likely belongs to before touching a setting. Changing configuration to see if it helps destroys the evidence and often creates a second problem.
- **Evidence before escalation.** A ticket that does not carry the five intake facts (page 3) is not ready to move. Tier 2 returns it.

Reading the trees

Every branch flows top to bottom. Questions are answered from evidence you can see (a screen, a report, a dialog), not from what the user believes. Follow Yes and No labels. Horizontal arrows lead to outcomes for the current question; vertical arrows continue the investigation.



The six layers and their colors

Layer 1	Identity and Entitlement	Correct user and account state; Copilot license; prerequisite plan (GCC: Microsoft 365 G5, G3, F1; Office 365 G5, G3, G1, F3); required service plans enabled.
Layer 2	Administrative Policy	Is Copilot enabled for this population; is a feature restricted; is web search allowed in this context; is the agent available to this user.
Layer 3	Client and Application	Web versus desktop; correct account; Microsoft 365 Apps for enterprise; build above 20131.20000 or Current Channel; network reach to copilot.cloud.microsoft.
Layer 4	Data and Permissions	Can the user open the source directly; is it indexed; is discoverability restricted (Restricted Content Discovery); duplicates or superseded copies.
Layer 5	Service	Health > Service health incidents and advisories; scope (one user or many); recent Message center changes.
Layer 6	Request and Expectation	What exactly was asked; is it supported in this app, license and GCC today; prompt grounding; probabilistic answers versus deterministic expectations.

Tiers referenced in the trees

Tier 0 self-service (FAQ, prompting guide, known behaviors). **Tier 1** help desk: intake, Layers 1 to 3 checks, classification; read access, no tenant changes. **Tier 2** Copilot operations: tenant settings, policy, agent Registry actions, licensing configuration, cross-user patterns, Microsoft support requests (AI Administrator for change, AI Reader for visibility). **Tier 3** specialists: Identity, Endpoint, SharePoint, Purview, Power Platform, Networking, Security, agent developers. **External:** Microsoft Support, opened by Tier 2 with the evidence package.

Intake gate: five facts every ticket needs

Do not enter any branch until all five are recorded. If the user cannot supply one, obtain it on the first call. These five facts are the mandatory fields in the Copilot Ticket Intake Template.

Who?	One user, a group, a department, or everybody? Name the population, not just the requester.	Decides whether Branch S (multi-user) runs first.
Where?	Which app (Copilot app, Teams, Outlook, Word, Excel, PowerPoint, OneNote, SharePoint), which mode (Work or Web), which client (browser, desktop, mobile), which device.	Decides Layer 2 versus Layer 3 questions; mode decides most web and grounding questions.
What?	What the user expected and what they observed, in their words. Include the exact prompt for answer-quality tickets and the exact error text for failures.	Separates expectation tickets (Layer 6) from failures.
When?	When did it last work and when did it first fail? Time zone. For reports: which window and when it was viewed.	Correlates with license changes, Service health onset, and reporting latency.
What changed?	License, group membership, policy, app update, content moved or renamed, network, agent, or a Microsoft change (Message center).	Points at the layer before any check is run.

Two optional facts that save an escalation

- **File > Account screenshot** (desktop app tickets): shows the signed-in account, product, version, build and update channel in one image. Builds above 20131.20000 indicate Version 2606 or later.
- **The citation** (answer-quality and find-my-file tickets): the document Copilot actually used. Open it before forming any theory.

Stop rules

- If three or more users report the same symptom within fifteen minutes, or a whole team reports at once, stop the individual triage and go to Branch S.
- If any check in a branch would require changing a tenant setting, a policy, a license or a SharePoint permission, stop. Tier 1 records the finding and routes; it does not change.
- If the user's own words describe a feature that GCC does not have yet (inline document editing, scheduled prompts, Word, Excel or PowerPoint Agents), go to Branch E and use the GCC Feature Reference. No amount of client troubleshooting will create a feature that has not been released.

Evidence package for any escalation

The five facts; the exact prompt or error text with time and time zone; File > Account screenshot; output of the Copilot Service Plan Diagnostic where licensing is in question; the citation where content is in question; the Service health check result and time; a list of what was already tried and the result. For Microsoft support requests, add Copilot diagnostics logs submitted from Copilot > Settings > Other settings by an AI Administrator.

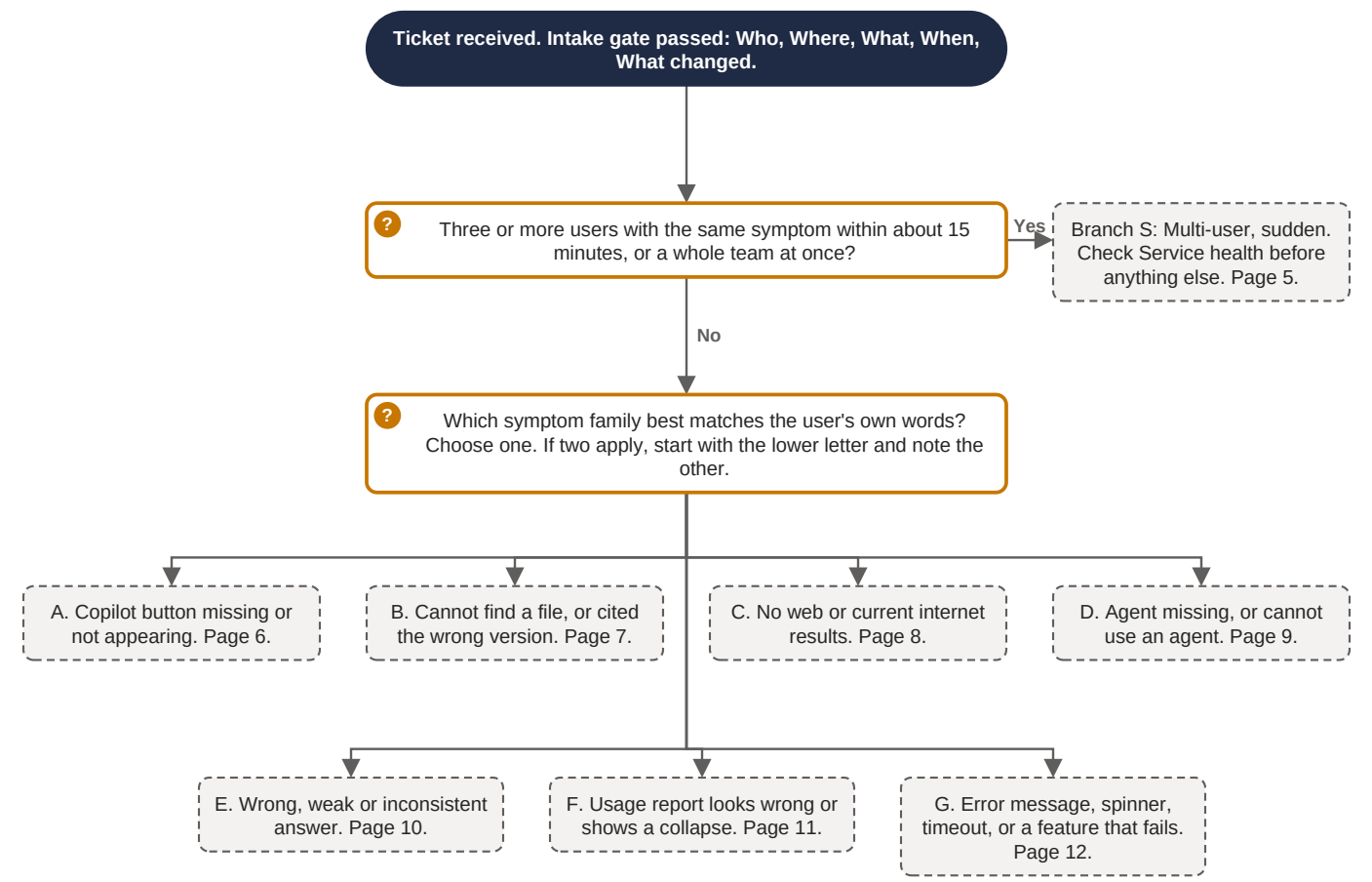
What Tier 1 can read in the GPO tenant

Users > Active users > Licenses and apps (license and service plans). Health > Service health (incidents and advisories). Word > File > Account on the user's device (with the user). Copilot > Settings and Agents > All agents > Registry with the AI Reader role (read only). Reports > Usage with Reports Reader. Anything beyond reading is Tier 2 or Tier 3.

Tree 0: Master router

Start here for every ticket. Scope first, then symptom family.

All layers



At any point in any branch: if the same symptom appears for several users, jump to Branch S.

Notes for this branch

- Scope decides order. One user with three symptoms is three tickets (log them separately); twenty users with one symptom is one investigation.
- Symptom families map to where the cause usually lives: A to Layers 1 and 3; B to Layer 4; C and D to Layer 2; E to Layer 6; F to Layer 6 (reporting); G to Layers 3 and 5. The trees still make you prove it.
- The user's words are the input, not the diagnosis. 'Copilot is broken' becomes A, B, C, E or G once you ask Where and What.
- Time budget: Tier 1 should reach an outcome or route node within 15 minutes for A, C, D and F, and within 25 minutes for B, E and G.

Record these six outputs for every ticket, whatever branch it follows

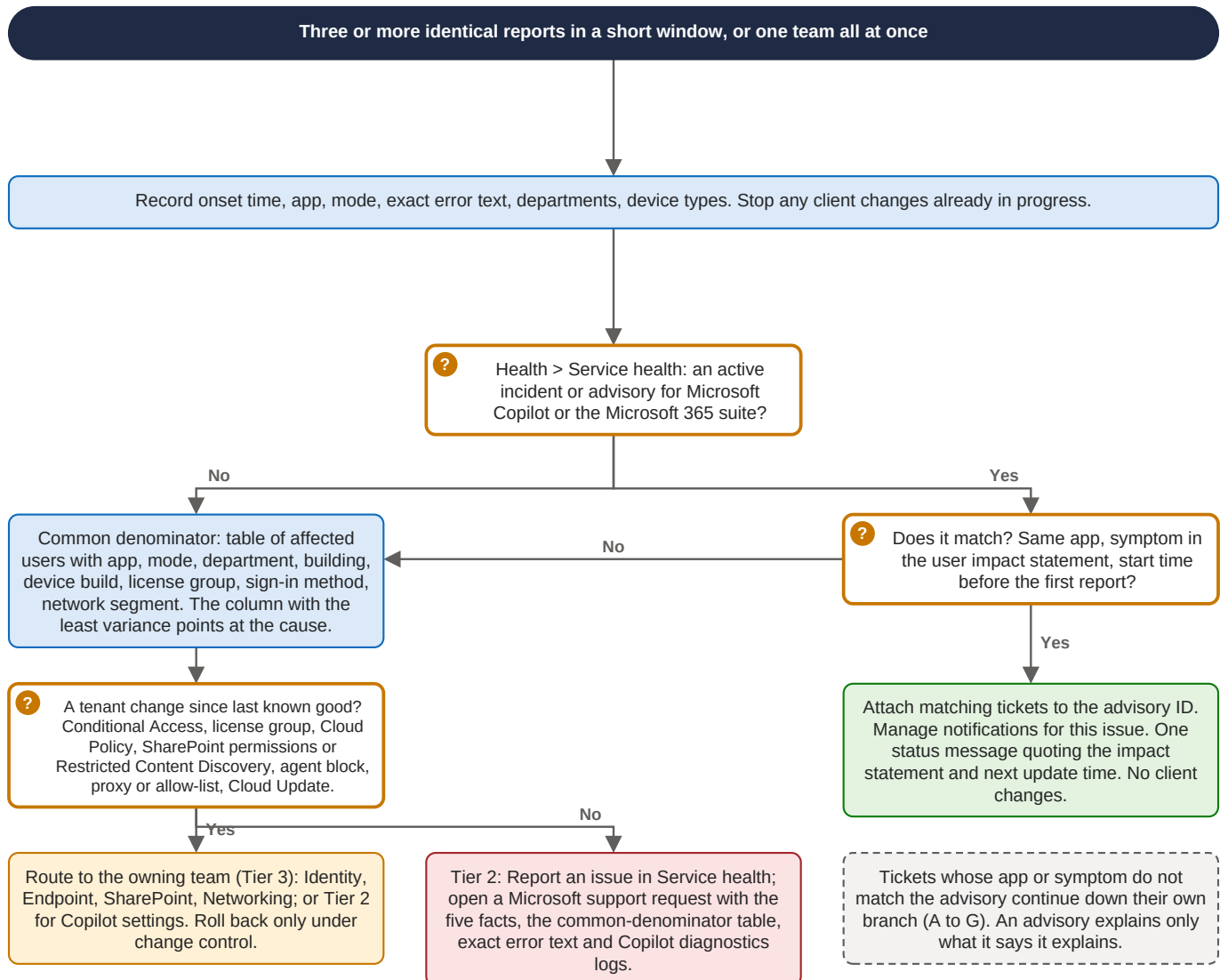
1. Affected user(s) and experience	Population and the Copilot surface: app, mode (Work or Web), client, device.
2. Likely troubleshooting layer	One of six. Name a second if the ticket straddles two.
3. Evidence required and first check	What you collected before changing anything, and the single first investigative step.
4. Administrative surface to investigate	The admin center, page, report or tool an administrator would open.
5. User action recommended	What the user does now, including 'nothing, and here is why' when that is the honest answer.
6. Escalation required? Destination?	Tier 2, a Tier 3 specialist team, Microsoft Support, or none. Attach the evidence package.

Branch S: Multi-user, sudden

Layer 5 first. One Service health check can close forty tickets; forty client fixes cannot close one service incident.

Layer 5 Service

Layer 3 Client and Application (if no advisory)



Notes for this branch

- Service health path: Microsoft 365 admin center > Health > Service health > Overview. Incidents are critical with noticeable impact; advisories are limited or lower impact. Record the ID.
- Evidence standard for attaching a ticket to an advisory: same app, same symptom in the user impact statement, and a start time before the first report. A ticket failing one test is triaged on its own branch.
- GCC: Service health reflects the GCC service instance. A commercial outage in the news does not mean GPO is affected, and a GPO advisory may not be visible to commercial customers.
- Report an issue is a signal that you see impact Microsoft has not posted. A support request (Support > New service request) is the case; AI Administrator or Service Support Administrator can open it. Communication template in extended notes.

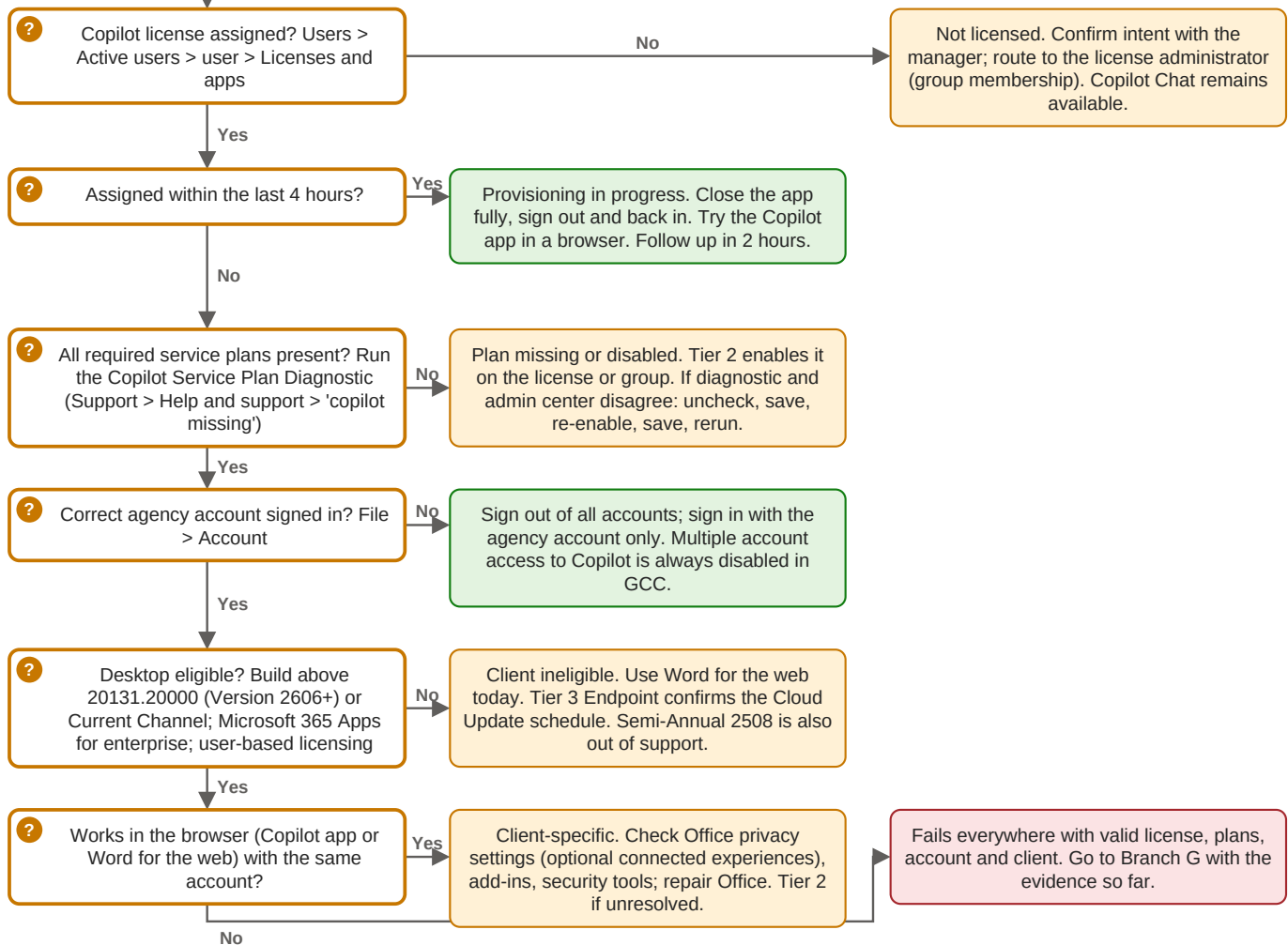
Branch A: Copilot button missing or not appearing

Layers 1 and 3. Cheap, deterministic checks in cost order. Most tickets end at the second or fifth question.

Layer 1 Identity and Entitlement

Layer 3 Client and Application

One user: no Copilot button in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, OneNote or Teams, or the Copilot app shows no Work mode



Notes for this branch

- Provisioning: the directory shows the license in minutes; workloads finish on their own schedule; the client must sign in again. Tier 2 can read ProvisioningStatus per plan with Get-MgUserLicenseDetail; PendingProvisioning shortly after assignment is normal.
- The diagnostic lists Copilot service plans on the account; it does not evaluate eligibility. No Copilot in Word means Microsoft 365 Copilot in Productivity Apps is absent or disabled. Requires AI Administrator.
- GCC prerequisites: Microsoft 365 G5, G3, F1; Office 365 G5, G3, G1, F3 (plus Exchange, SharePoint, OneDrive, Visio plans). Say G3 and G5 to a GPO user.
- Since July 2026, Semi-Annual devices that installed Version 2606 report Monthly Enterprise Channel and are eligible; management tools may still show the old label. The build number is the truth. See extended notes.

Branch B: Cannot find a file, or cited the wrong version

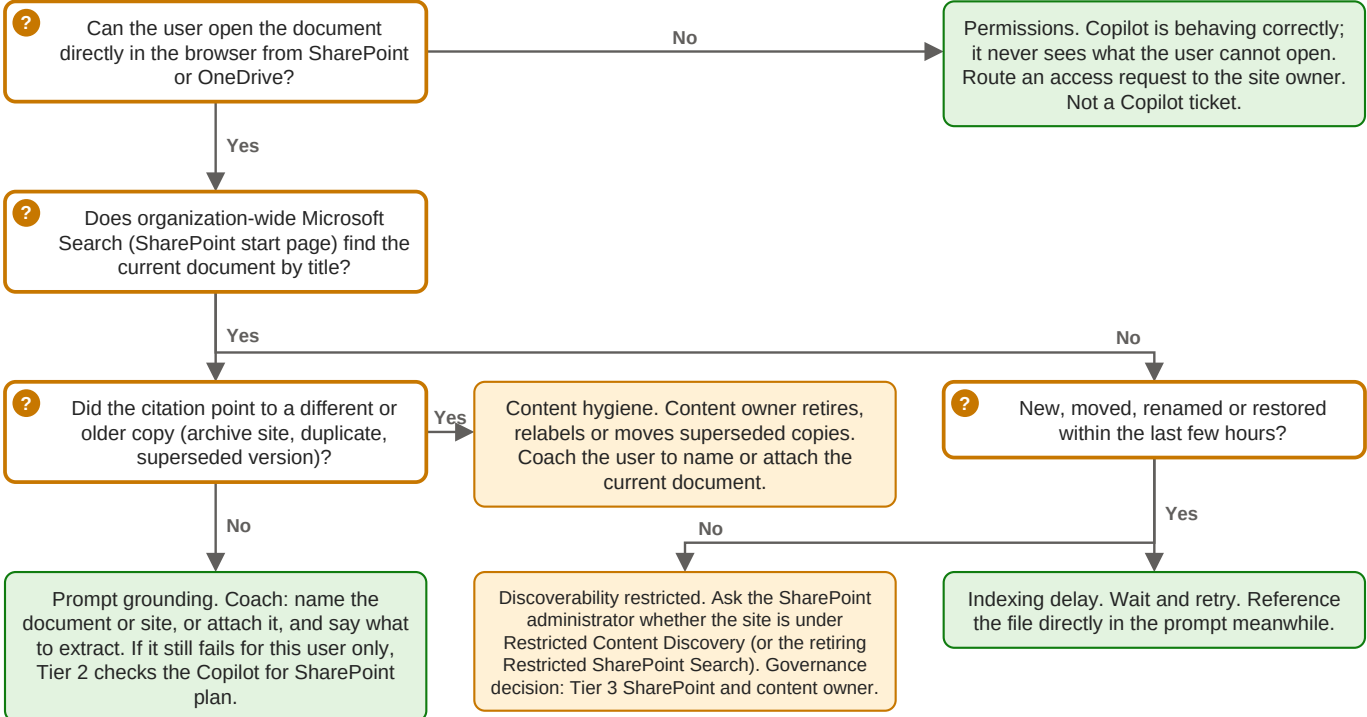
Layer 4 first, then Layer 6. The critical question: can the user open it without Copilot? If not, Copilot is right.

Layer 4 Data and Permissions

Layer 6 Request and Expectation

One user: Copilot cannot find a document, or cited the wrong version of one

Get the exact prompt and the citation Copilot returned. Note the document's site and library and when it last worked. Content on a file share, local disk or personal cloud is out of Copilot's reach: route to Tier 2 for a supported location or a Copilot Connector.



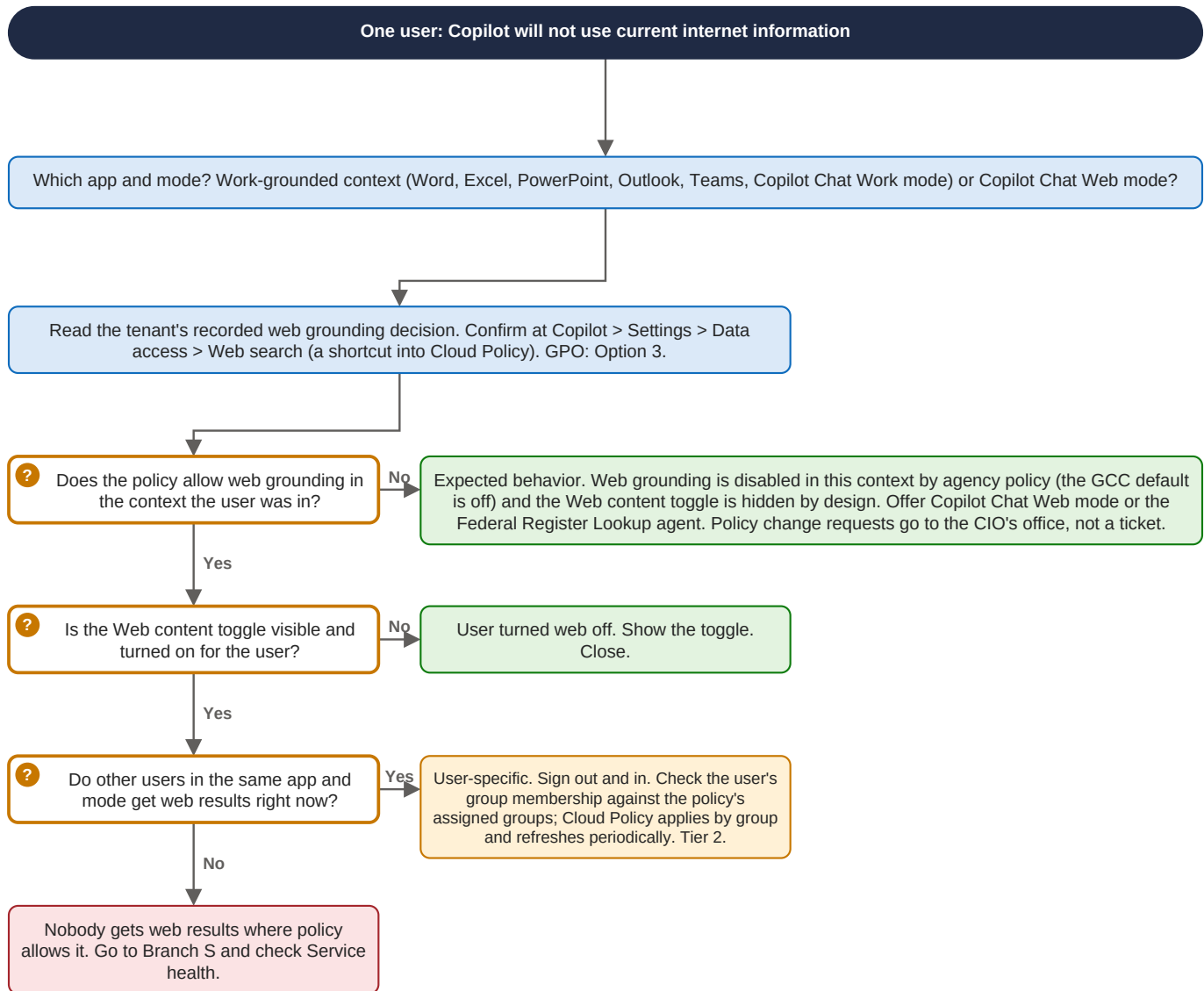
Notes for this branch

- Copilot grounds only on content the signed-in user can already open and that has been indexed. Permission changes, moves and renames are the usual causes of 'it worked yesterday'.
- Restricted Content Discovery hides a site from organization-wide search and Copilot without changing permissions. Since late July 2026 (MC1427972), recently viewed files on RCD sites no longer resurface and Copilot entry points are removed there. A policy library under RCD is invisible to Copilot for everyone.
- The 'wrong version' pattern: the current copy sits on an RCD site; a superseded copy sits on an archive site the user can still read. Copilot summarizes the only version it may discover. The citation tells the story.
- Sensitivity labels with encryption and Purview DLP for Copilot prompts (available in GCC) can also limit what Copilot summarizes. A policy message in the answer belongs to Branch G's first question. See extended notes.

Branch C: No web or current internet results

Layer 2. In GCC this is expected configuration far more often than a fault. Tier 1 explains policy; Tier 1 never changes policy.

Layer 2 Administrative Policy



Notes for this branch

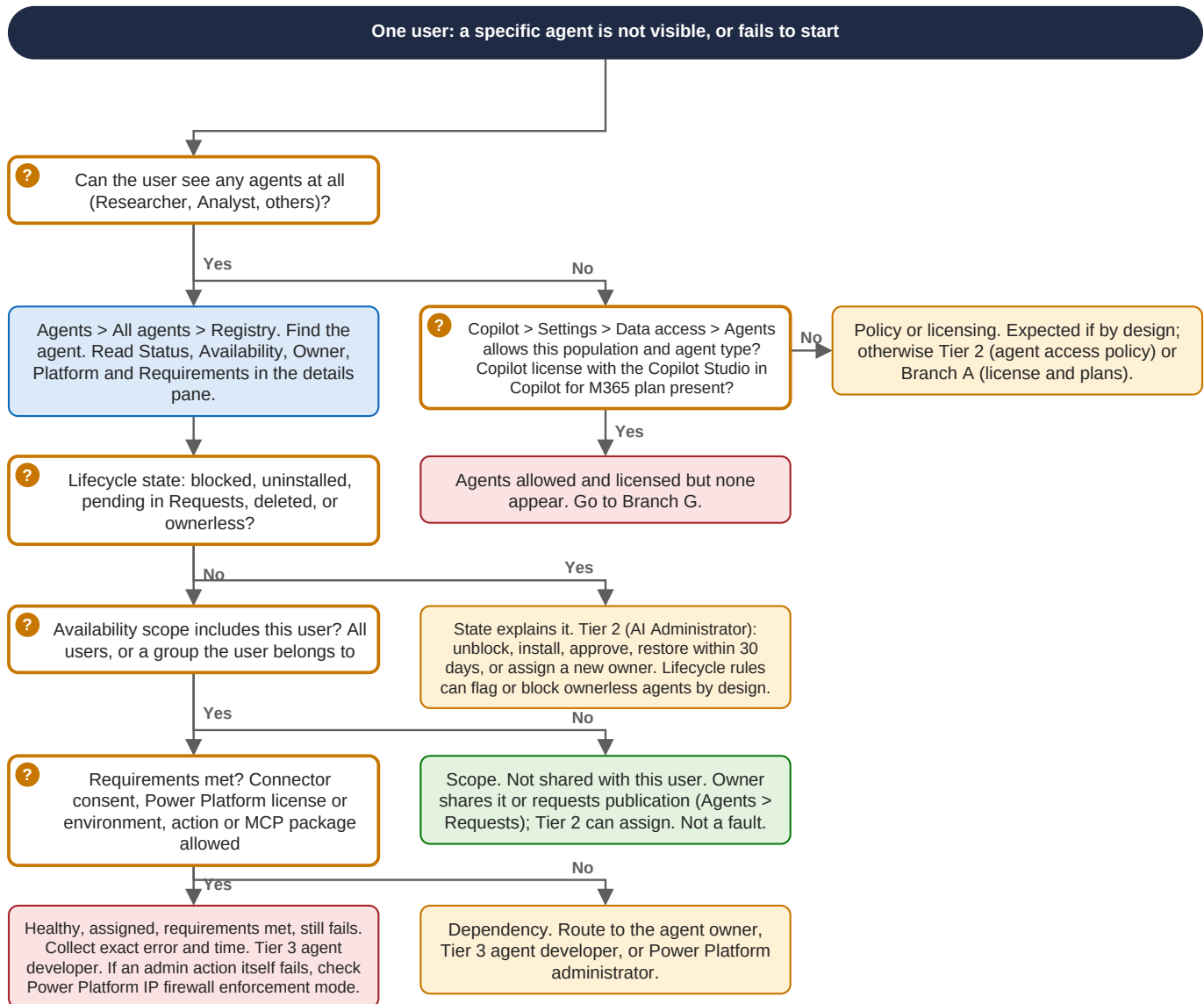
- GCC default: if the Allow web search in Copilot policy is not configured, web search is off for Microsoft Copilot and Copilot Chat regardless of the optional connected experiences setting. Enabling requires Cloud Policy service (config.office.com).
- Three options when enabled: (1) enabled in Microsoft Copilot and Copilot Chat; (2) disabled in both; (3) disabled in Work mode, enabled in Web mode and Copilot Chat. GPO runs Option 3 (CIO and General Counsel, April 2026).
- Signature of Option 3: 'Web works in Copilot Chat but not in Word or Work mode.' That is the policy working. Toggle rule: allowed means the user may turn web off; disabled means the toggle is hidden and cannot be turned on.
- Web grounding sends a derived search query to Bing with user and tenant identifiers removed. The agency decision is about whether a derived query may leave the tenant boundary, which is why Tier 1 does not own the setting. See extended notes.

Branch D: Agent missing, or cannot use an agent

Layer 2 and the Agents workload. Registry first (the state of the agent), access policy second (may this population use agents at all).

Layer 2 Administrative Policy

Layer 1 Identity and Entitlement (plan check)



Notes for this branch

- Registry path: Agents > All agents (Registry). Block, Unblock, Install and Uninstall sit under the agent name in the details pane. Approving requests and assigning ownership require AI Administrator or Global Administrator.
- Blocking an Agent Builder or Copilot Studio agent removes it from Copilot, Teams and Outlook. Blocking a SharePoint or Foundry agent affects only Copilot Chat. Researcher and Analyst are managed only by tenant-wide Block.
- Ownerless agents (creator left) surface on Agents > Overview and lifecycle rules can flag or block them. 'Our agent disappeared' after a departure is usually this; fix is Assign new owner, then unblock.
- GCC: Agent Builder and declarative agents are available; organization publishing is supported in GCC Moderate. Agent 365 arrives in phases from October 1, 2026. See extended notes.

Branch E: Wrong, weak or inconsistent answer

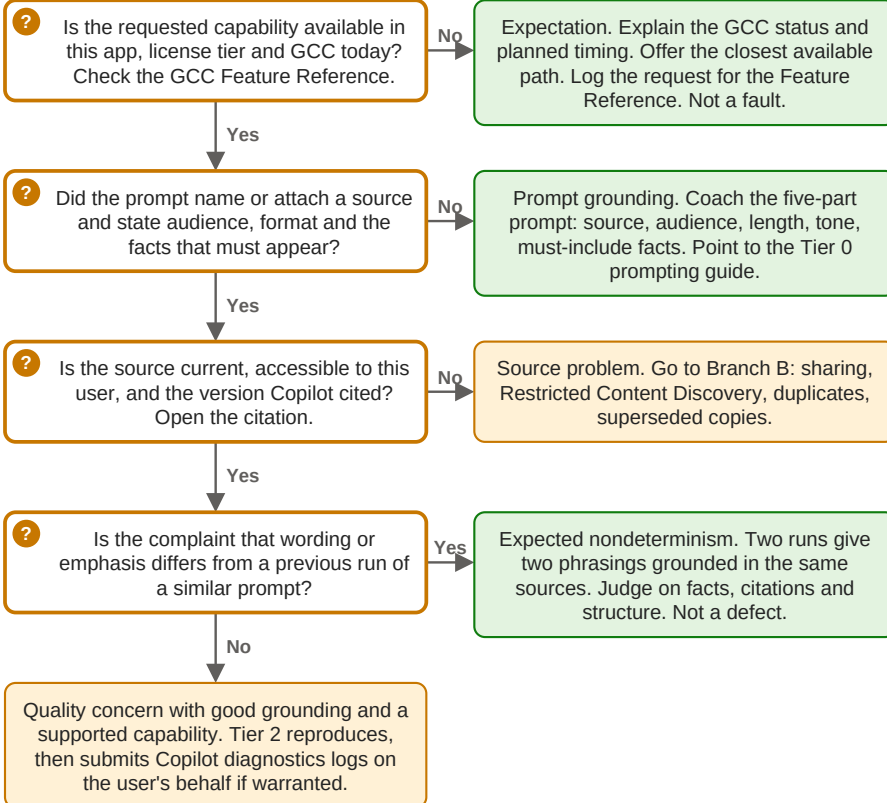
Layer 6 first, then Layer 4. Three kinds of wrong: technical (an error), data (stale or wrong source), expectation (feature absent, or probabilistic behavior). Only the first is an incident.

Layer 6 Request and Expectation

Layer 4 Data and Permissions

One user: the answer is wrong, weak, generic, or different from a previous run

Capture the exact prompt, app, mode, the full answer and the citations. Read them before forming a theory. If there is an error message, timeout, spinner or blank response, this is Branch G, not E.



Notes for this branch

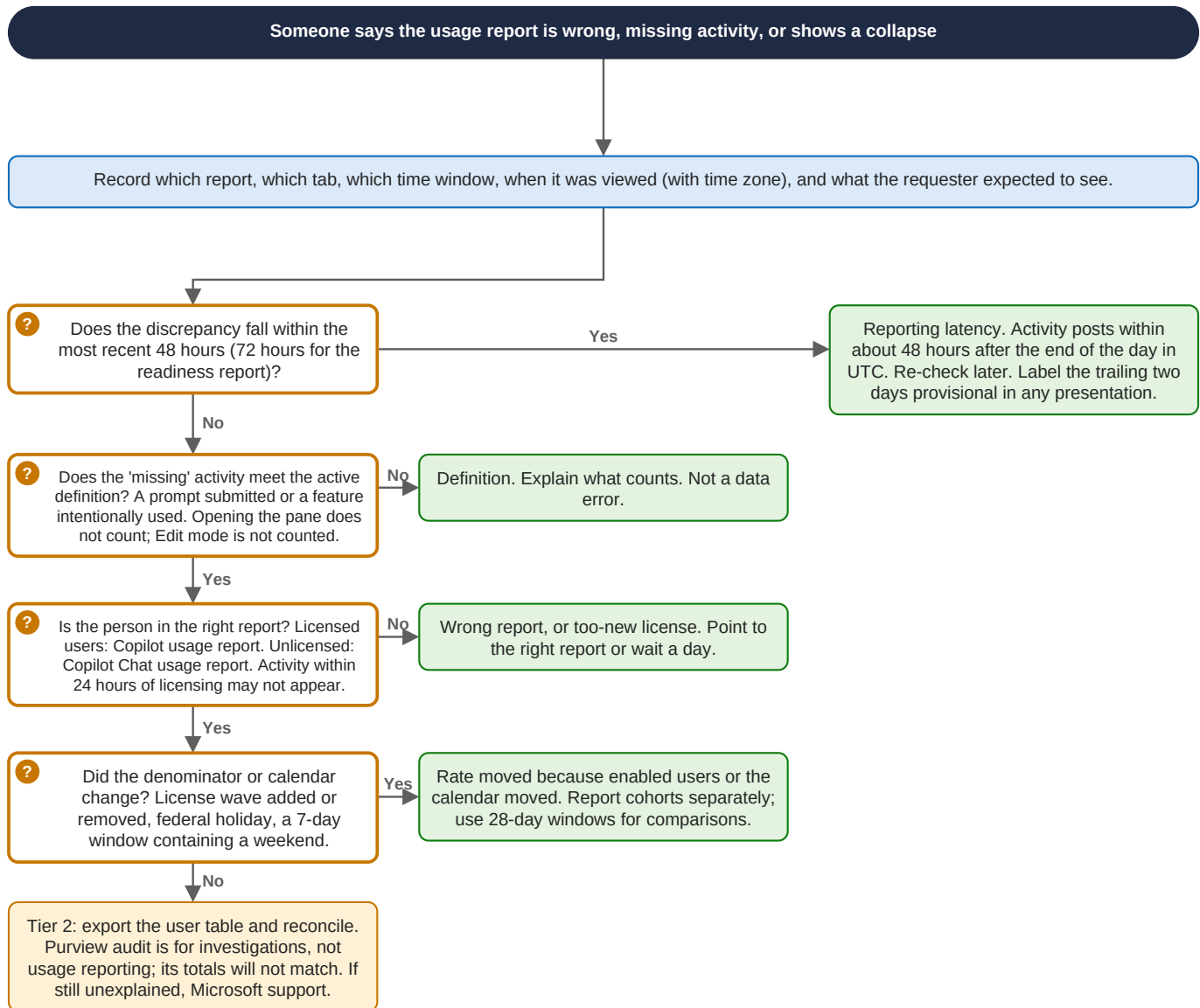
- GCC Feature Reference, September 2026: not yet available are Edit with Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and OneNote; Word, Excel and PowerPoint Agents; Scheduled Prompts; Copilot app on Mac desktop; Copilot Chat in the Edge sidebar; Schedule with Copilot and Themes in Outlook. Excel structured analysis is impacted until Edit ships.
- A user who asks Copilot to rewrite a document in place, run a prompt on a schedule, or analyze an Excel table the way a commercial demo showed is asking for something GCC does not have yet. No troubleshooting will produce the feature.
- Language for users: 'Copilot writes the most likely good answer from the documents it can see. If two documents look similar, it may pick the one you did not mean. Let us point it at the right one.'
- Hallucination defense: grounding (name the source), verification (open the citations), and treating Copilot as a drafting colleague, not a system of record. See extended notes.

Branch F: Usage report looks wrong or shows a collapse

Layer 6, about how reporting works. Service health never explains a usage report; a usage report never shows today's incident.

Layer 6 Request and Expectation

Monitoring module



Notes for this branch

- Paths: Reports > Usage > Microsoft Copilot > Copilot (Usage tab, Readiness tab); Reports > Usage > Microsoft Copilot > Copilot Chat (unlicensed users). Windows: 7, 28, 90 or 180 days. Names are anonymized by default.
- Latency: activity for a day becomes available within about 48 hours after that day ends in UTC. Daily validation for the past three days backfills gaps, so historical numbers can shift slightly. Readiness report: within 72 hours, up to 72 hours latency.
- Definitions: enabled users held a license at any point in the window; active users took an intentional Copilot action; rate is active divided by enabled. A new license wave lowers the rate before it raises it.
- GCC: the Copilot usage report reached GA in GCC in October 2025 and the Copilot Chat usage report in July 2026. Verify the readiness and agent usage reports exist in the GPO tenant before promising them. See extended notes.

Branch G: Error message, spinner, timeout, or a feature that fails

Layers 3 and 5 for one user. Isolate the client and the network before suspecting the service; a single user is rarely a service incident.

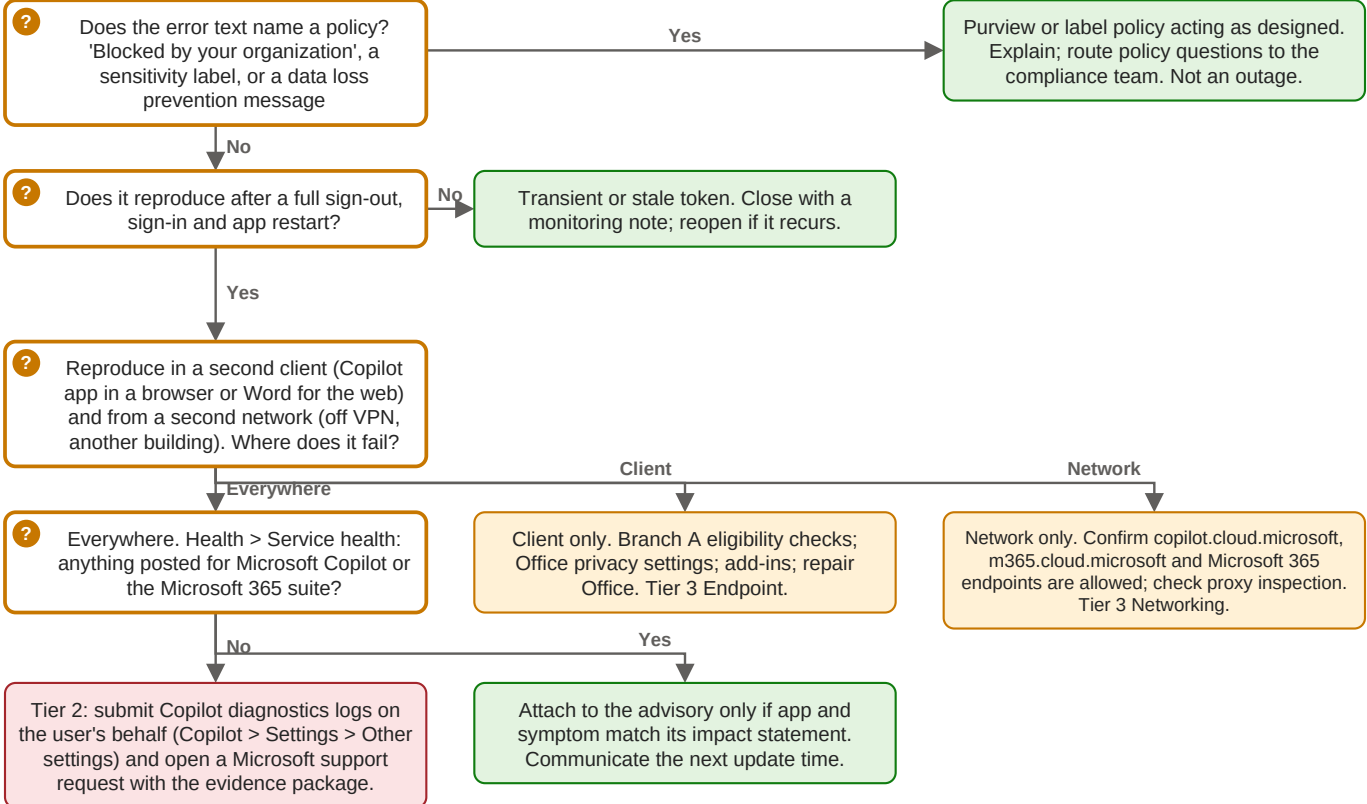
Layer 3 Client and Application

Layer 5 Service

Layer 2 Administrative Policy (DLP)

One user: explicit error, spinner, timeout, blank response, or a feature that used to work now fails

Capture exact error text, time with time zone, app, mode, device, signed-in account and network location (office, VPN, home). Screenshot.



Notes for this branch

- Two isolation tests do most of the work: a second client (browser versus desktop) separates Layer 3 from everything else; a second network separates proxy and allow-list problems from the tenant. Do them before any reinstall.
- Policy messages are not errors. Purview DLP for Copilot prompts (available in GCC) blocks prompts containing sensitive information and returns a policy message; encrypted sensitivity labels can prevent summarization. Both are Layer 2 acting as designed.
- Copilot diagnostics logs: an AI Administrator can submit prompts, responses, content samples and log files to Microsoft for a specific issue when the user cannot. This is how a hard case gets real evidence to Microsoft.
- Network: the Copilot app's primary URL is moving from m365.cloud.microsoft to copilot.cloud.microsoft; a redirect to a blocked host fails. Add the new host to egress allow-lists. Three or more users with the same error in fifteen minutes is Branch S, not G.

Escalation matrix and hand-off standards

Where each layer's tickets go when Tier 1 cannot close them, what each tier is allowed to do, and what must travel with the ticket. Names and roles are the GPO operating model; adjust as the model matures.

Layer	Tier 1 (help desk) may	Tier 2 (Copilot operations) may	Tier 3 specialist	Microsoft Support when
1 Identity and Entitlement	Read license and service plans; run the Service Plan Diagnostic if granted AI Reader-level access to the support pane; confirm account state; advise sign-out and in; set follow-up	Enable or fix service plans; manage licensing groups; fix diagnostic and admin center disagreements; run Get-MgUserLicenseDetail	Identity team: Conditional Access, sign-in risk, account lifecycle	Plans show Success everywhere and the diagnostic matches, yet Copilot is absent after 24 hours on an eligible client
2 Administrative Policy	Read and explain recorded policy decisions (web grounding, agent access); confirm expected behavior; log policy change requests	Read Cloud Policy and Copilot settings; verify group targeting; propose changes through change control (AI Administrator)	CIO office for web grounding decisions; Purview for DLP and labels	A documented policy option is not producing its documented behavior across users
3 Client and Application	File > Account; browser test; sign-out and in; check build against 20131.20000; Word for the web workaround	Confirm device eligibility with the Apps admin center inventory; identify Office privacy settings; coordinate Office repair	Endpoint team: Cloud Update, channel, build baseline; Networking: allow-lists and proxy	Eligible client, valid entitlement, reproduces on a second device and network, no policy message
4 Data and Permissions	'Can you open it directly?' test; SharePoint start page search; open the citation; ask about moves and renames	Confirm RCD or RSS status with SharePoint admin; request Copilot Connector evaluation; coordinate content hygiene with owners	SharePoint team: permissions, RCD inventory, SharePoint Advanced Management; content owners	Content is open to the user, indexed, discoverable in search, correctly named in the prompt, and still not grounded
5 Service	Check Health > Service health; record advisory ID; stop client changes; send status communication	Attach tickets with matching evidence; subscribe to issue notifications; Report an issue; open support request	Not applicable (Microsoft-owned) unless the common denominator points at a tenant change	No advisory posted, common denominator found nothing, and impact spans users, clients and networks
6 Request and Expectation	Read the prompt; check the GCC Feature Reference; coach the five-part prompt; explain nondeterminism and reporting latency	Reproduce quality concerns; submit diagnostics logs; maintain the Feature Reference; report to adoption team	Adoption and training team; Tier 0 content owner	Reproducible, well-grounded, supported-capability answers that are materially wrong, with diagnostics logs attached

Hand-off standards

- **Tier 1 to Tier 2:** the five facts, the branch followed and the node reached, evidence collected (screenshots, diagnostic output, citation), what was tried and the result. A ticket without the branch and node is returned.
- **Tier 2 to Tier 3:** everything above plus the specific change or decision requested, the population affected, and the business impact. Tier 3 owns the service; Tier 2 owns the Copilot context.
- **Tier 2 to Microsoft:** everything above plus Copilot diagnostics logs, the Service health check result and time, tenant ID, affected UPNs (with authorization), exact reproduction steps, and confirmation that the behavior contradicts Microsoft Learn documentation. Follow agency data handling rules for what may be shared in a case.
- **Any tier to the user:** what was found, what it means in plain language, what the user should do now, and when they will hear next. For expected-behavior outcomes, cite the policy or the GCC status so the answer carries authority rather than apology.

GCC quick reference, click paths and sources

Expected by design in GCC (not faults)

- Web grounding is off unless the Allow web search in Copilot Cloud Policy enables it. GPO runs Option 3: off in Work mode, on in Web mode and Copilot Chat. The Web content toggle is hidden where policy disables web.
- Multiple account access to Copilot is always disabled. Copilot Chat in the Edge sidebar and the Copilot app as a Mac desktop app are not available. Copilot Chat in the Office web apps is not available to users without a Copilot license.
- Copilot Connectors: external connections and partner connectors are not enabled by default. Copilot Analytics in Viva Insights exposes a limited set of core metrics.

Not yet available in GCC (September 2026)

- Edit with Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and OneNote; Word, Excel and PowerPoint Agents; Scheduled Prompts; Schedule with Copilot and Themes by Copilot in Outlook. Excel structured data analysis is impacted until Edit with Copilot in Excel ships. Microsoft 365 G7 and Agent 365 purchasable from October 1, 2026; Edit with Copilot, Work IQ memory, newer models and Copilot Cowork planned in the months after GA.

Click paths used in this document (verify in the GPO tenant)

Service Plan Diagnostic	Microsoft 365 admin center > Support > Help and support > type 'copilot missing' > Run diagnostics > enter UPN > Run tests. Requires AI Administrator. Lists Copilot service plans on the account.
User license and plans	Users > Active users > user > Licenses and apps > expand Apps.
Group-based licensing	Billing > Licenses > select product > Assign licenses > choose group > Turn apps and services on or off > Assign. Errors & issues tab for failures.
Copilot settings	Copilot > Settings: User access, Data access (Agents, Web search, licensing recommendations), Copilot actions, Other settings (Copilot diagnostics logs).
Agent Registry	Agents > All agents (Registry). Details pane: Block or Unblock, Install or Uninstall, Assign new owner. Agents > Requests for approvals. Agents > Overview for ownerless and at-risk agents.
Web search policy	Copilot > Settings > Data access > Web search (shortcut into Cloud Policy service at config.office.com). Read only for Tier 1 and Tier 2 without change control.
Service health	Health > Service health > Overview; select an advisory for details and Manage notifications for this issue; Customize > Email for notifications; Report an issue.
Usage and readiness reports	Reports > Usage > Microsoft Copilot > Copilot (Readiness tab, Usage tab); Reports > Usage > Microsoft Copilot > Copilot Chat.
Device build and channel	Word > File > Account > About Word. Version 2606 or later shows a build above 20131.20000. Inventory and Cloud Update in the Microsoft 365 Apps admin center.
Discoverability controls	SharePoint admin center > Active sites > site > Settings (Restricted Content Discovery), or SharePoint Online Management Shell. Coordinate with the SharePoint administrator.

Extended notes by branch

Longer explanations that did not fit beside the trees. Read once; refer back when a ticket does not match the short notes.

Branch S: communication template and evidence

Template: 'Microsoft is reporting [ID]: [user impact statement quoted]. Affected: Copilot in [app]. Unaffected: [apps confirmed working]. Workaround: [alternative]. Next Microsoft update: [time]. No action is needed from you; do not reinstall or reset anything.' Send once per advisory, then update only when Microsoft posts a change. For the common-denominator table, capture for each affected user: app and mode, department, building or network segment, device model and Office build, license group, sign-in method (password, phishing-resistant MFA, device compliance) and whether the user is on VPN. The column with the least variance points at the cause. If nothing is found and Service health stays silent, the support request should say so explicitly: 'no tenant change identified since [date]; reproduces across [N] users, [N] device types, [N] networks.'

Branch A: provisioning, plans, channels

License assignment is quick in the directory but each workload provisions on its own schedule and a client holds the token it signed in with. The Copilot usage report FAQ notes that activity within 24 hours of assignment may not appear in reporting, which tells you Microsoft expects a settling window. Group-based licensing (Billing > Licenses > product > Assign licenses > group) makes the pilot or the wave a group membership decision; the Errors and issues tab on the product page shows users who did not receive a license and why (insufficient licenses, conflicting service plans, missing dependencies, usage location). The Copilot Service Plan Diagnostic (Support > Help and support > 'copilot missing') lists the Copilot service plans on the account: Microsoft 365 Copilot in Productivity Apps, in Microsoft Teams, for SharePoint, Microsoft Copilot with Graph-grounded chat, Graph Connectors, Power Platform Connectors, Intelligent Search, Copilot Studio in Copilot for M365. A second Microsoft-recommended check, Copilot License Details (aka.ms/CopilotLicenseDetails), verifies that an account meets Copilot requirements. On channels: beginning with Version 2606 in July 2026 Microsoft unified Semi-Annual Enterprise Channel into Monthly Enterprise Channel; devices that installed 2606 show Monthly Enterprise Channel in File > Account and become eligible; SAEC Version 2508 left support on September 8, 2026; Intune and Configuration Manager may still display the old channel label, so use the build (above 20131.20000). Cloud Update in the Microsoft 365 Apps admin center takes precedence over other update tools and automatically onboards eligible devices after 2606. Copilot is not available with device-based licensing; the user must be the licensed principal.

Branch B: the data layer

Four mechanisms decide whether a file is findable. Permissions: SharePoint and OneDrive permissions are the boundary and Copilot never elevates. Indexing: content must be crawled into the search index and the semantic index; new or moved items appear after minutes to hours. Discoverability controls: Restricted Content Discovery (a site setting in SharePoint Advanced Management, included with Copilot licensing) removes a site from organization-wide search and Copilot without changing access, and since MC1427972 (late July 2026) files a user recently viewed on an RCD site no longer resurface and Copilot entry points are removed from those sites; Restricted SharePoint Search, the older tenant allow-list, is retiring with new enablement blocked from July 31, 2026. Labels and DLP: sensitivity labels with encryption can restrict summarization; Purview DLP for Copilot prompts (available in GCC) can block a prompt and return a policy message. The test sequence on the tree (open directly, search from the SharePoint start page, open the citation) covers all four in the cheapest order. When a whole policy library is under RCD, escalate the governance question: an RCD-protected policy site defeats one of Copilot's most common uses, and the SharePoint team should decide deliberately.

Branch C: what the policy controls

The Allow web search in Copilot policy lives in Cloud Policy service for Microsoft 365 (config.office.com) and is linked from Copilot > Settings > Data access > Web search. It is assigned to Microsoft Entra groups and applies to the user, not the device, when the user signs in to Microsoft 365 Apps and Copilot experiences; changes are picked up periodically and a sign-out and sign-in accelerates them. In GCC and DoD, an unconfigured policy means web search is off in both Microsoft Copilot and Copilot Chat regardless of the optional connected experiences setting; commercial tenants default to on. When enabled, Copilot may generate a search query derived from the user's prompt and send it to Bing with user and tenant identifiers removed; results return as grounding and appear in citations. Option 3 (disabled in Work mode; enabled in Web

mode and Copilot Chat) keeps prompts that touch organizational data off the public web while permitting general web chat; it produces the 'works in Copilot Chat, not in Word' pattern by design. GPO's decision was made by the CIO and General Counsel in April 2026. Change requests are policy requests to that office, with a record in the knowledge base, never a help desk fix.

Branch D: agent lifecycle and governance

Agents have their own workload in the Microsoft 365 admin center: Agents > Overview (a 30-day governance dashboard with pending requests, agents without owners, agents at risk and agents with exceptions), Agents > All agents with Registry selected (the inventory of Microsoft, partner, organization-published and user-created agents) and Agents > Requests (the approval queue). Lifecycle actions in the details pane include Install and Uninstall (to all users or specific users and groups, with a permissions review and admin consent), Block and Unblock (organization-wide), Delete with a 30-day recovery window, Restore, Permanently delete, Assign new owner (Agent Builder and Copilot Studio agents), and Add or Remove owner (Agent Builder agents support multiple owners; you cannot remove the last one). Approving requests and assigning ownership require AI Administrator or Global Administrator. Blocking an Agent Builder or Copilot Studio agent removes it from Copilot and host apps such as Outlook and Teams; blocking a SharePoint or Foundry agent affects only Copilot Chat; Researcher and Analyst cannot be scoped by user and are managed only by tenant-wide Block. If an admin action fails to apply, the agent may sit in a Power Platform environment whose IP firewall is in active enforcement mode, which rejects requests from the admin center's upstream service IP; check Power Platform admin center > Security > Identity and access > IP firewall. Copilot > Settings > Data access > Agents is the access policy for who may use agents and which types, and links back to the Registry through Manage all agents. In GCC, publishing agents to the organization is supported in GCC Moderate; Microsoft 365 G7 and Agent 365 become purchasable October 1, 2026, with capabilities expanding in phases.

Branch E: expectation, grounding and the GCC gap

Three kinds of wrong. Technical: an error, timeout or blank; Branch G. Data: the source is stale, duplicated, superseded or not shared with the user; Branch B. Expectation: the feature is not present in GCC, or the user expects a deterministic answer from a probabilistic system. Large language models generate the most likely good text given the prompt and the grounding; the same question asked twice produces two phrasings that agree on substance and differ in wording, which is not a defect. When grounding is thin, models can be confidently wrong, so the defenses are grounding (name or attach the source), verification (open the citations) and training users to treat Copilot as a drafting colleague rather than a system of record. The five-part prompt for coaching: source, audience, length, tone, must-include facts. On the GCC gap as of September 2026: Edit with Copilot in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and OneNote is not yet released, and the service description states that Copilot's ability to analyze structured Excel data is impacted until Edit with Copilot in Excel ships; Word, Excel and PowerPoint Agents and Scheduled Prompts are also not yet available. Microsoft has announced Edit with Copilot, Work IQ memory and personalization, the latest commercially available GPT models and Copilot Cowork for government clouds in the months after Microsoft 365 G7 general availability. Expect 'Copilot answers differently than last month' tickets when models change; that is expected behavior, and the Feature Reference should be re-verified quarterly against the service description feature table and the Microsoft 365 Roadmap filtered to GCC.

Branch F: reading reports like an operator

The Copilot usage report (Reports > Usage > Microsoft Copilot > Copilot, Usage tab) covers licensed users; the Copilot Chat usage report covers only users without a Copilot license; a user's license status decides which report they appear in. Enabled users are unique users who held a license at any point in the window, so a user licensed on day 27 of a 28-day window counts as enabled and depresses the rate. Active users are enabled users who submitted a prompt or intentionally invoked a feature; selecting the Copilot icon in Word to open the pane does not count. Excel and PowerPoint Edit mode are not yet counted in the Copilot Chat report's active usage. Activity for a given day becomes available within about 48 hours after that day ends in UTC, and daily validation for the past three days backfills gaps, so the trailing two days of any trend are provisional and historical numbers can shift slightly. The readiness report is available within 72 hours with up to 72 hours latency, defines the eligible update channel as Current Channel or Monthly Enterprise Channel (former SAEC devices that installed 2606 count), and flags Suggested candidates weekly (the top 25 percent of unlicensed users by app usage), which Microsoft states is not for evaluating employee performance. Purview audit records Copilot interactions for investigations; Microsoft states it is not intended for usage reporting and aggregates built from it will not match the reports. Use 28-day windows for comparisons and

account for federal holidays and weekends before interpreting a dip.

Branch G: the evidence package for Microsoft

Before a support request: the five facts; exact error text with time and time zone; File > Account screenshot; results of the second-client and second-network tests; the Service health check result and time; the Service Plan Diagnostic output; what was tried and the result; and Copilot diagnostics logs submitted from Copilot > Settings > Other settings by an AI Administrator, which temporarily overrides the user-level feedback policy so prompts, responses, content samples and log files reach Microsoft for the specific issue. Confirm agency data handling rules before attaching prompts and responses to a case. State plainly in the request that the behavior contradicts the documented behavior on Microsoft Learn and cite the page. Requests can be opened from Support > New service request by an AI Administrator or a Service Support Administrator.

Sources and revision log

Sources (Microsoft Learn, verified September 2026)

- Manage Microsoft Copilot settings in the Microsoft 365 admin center; Manage Microsoft Copilot Chat; Data, privacy and security for web search
- Microsoft Copilot service description, feature availability (August 5, 2026); Understand Microsoft US government cloud environments
- License options for Microsoft Copilot (US Government licenses); Copilot service plan diagnostic tool and service plans; Set up Microsoft Copilot
- Upcoming channel unification, Semi-Annual Enterprise Channel to Monthly Enterprise Channel; Change update channel to prepare devices for Copilot
- Microsoft Entra built-in roles (AI Administrator, AI Reader); Governance and lifecycle actions for agents; Agent management in Microsoft 365 admin center
- Microsoft Copilot usage report; Microsoft Copilot Chat usage report; Microsoft Copilot readiness report; How to check Microsoft 365 service health
- Restricted Content Discovery; Restricted SharePoint Search (retiring); Message center MC1274325 (channel unification) and MC1427972 (RCD enhancements)
- Microsoft announcements: Introducing Microsoft 365 G7 (September 15, 2026); What's new and What's next in Microsoft 365 Copilot for US Government customers (August and September 2026)

Revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	September 29, 2026	Initial release aligned to the Day 7 Copilot Operations course. Next scheduled review January 2027, or sooner when Microsoft 365 G7 capabilities land in GCC or the web grounding decision changes.